Short-characteristics transport — unigrid and octree

Detailed reference for the transport sweeps in `rt3d`: how characteristics are constructed on each spatial grid, how the formal solution is evaluated in a fully vectorized way, and how the pieces fit into the lambda-iteration loop of `rt3d.solver`.

Companion figures are generated by `scripts/sc_transport_figures.py` into `plot/` (they use the real `rt3d` geometry helpers, so they show exactly what the solver does).

Code under discussion:

file	role
`rt3d/geometry.py`	cuboid domain, `unigrid`, `ray_box_exit`, `march_lattice` (DDA on the lattice)
`rt3d/octree.py`	`octree_grid`, `march_octree` (DDA on the octree), `node_major_segments`
`rt3d/characteristics.py`	`build_chain` (unigrid), `build_chain_octree` (reference), stencils, sub-segments
`rt3d/transport.py`	`boundary_conditions`, `sweep_direction`, `sweep_all`, `precompute_octree_march`, `sweep_direction_octree_exact`, beam optical depths
`rt3d/solver.py`	`lambda_iteration` — drives the sweeps

1. Scope, notation, the formal solution

The solver is monochromatic, scalar, straight-ray (no refraction). For one ordinate $\mathbf{\Omega}$ and one target cell c, the *characteristic* is the straight line through c's center pointing upwind along $-\mathbf{\Omega}$. The intensity at the cell center is the formal solution of the RTE along that line.

Along the characteristic the traversed cells are $c_1, c_2, \ldots$ (in propagation order) and the path is split into **sub-segments** — maximal pieces inside one cell. With the source S piecewise constant per cell, the formal solution is **exact**:

$$I_c \;=\; I_{\text{in}}\, e^{-\tau_{\text{tot}}} \;+\; \sum_{\text{sub}} S_{\text{sub}} \underbrace{\left(1 - e^{-\tau_{\text{sub}}}\right)}_{\text{emit along sub}} \underbrace{e^{-\tau_{\text{after}}}}_{\text{absorb on the way to } c}$$

where

- $\tau_{\text{sub}} = \kappa_e[\text{cell of sub}] \cdot \ell_{\text{sub}}$ — optical depth of the sub-segment itself,
- τ_{after} — optical depth of all path between that sub-segment and the target center,
- τ_{tot} — total optical depth of the whole characteristic,
- I_{in} — inflow intensity at the domain entry point (§7).

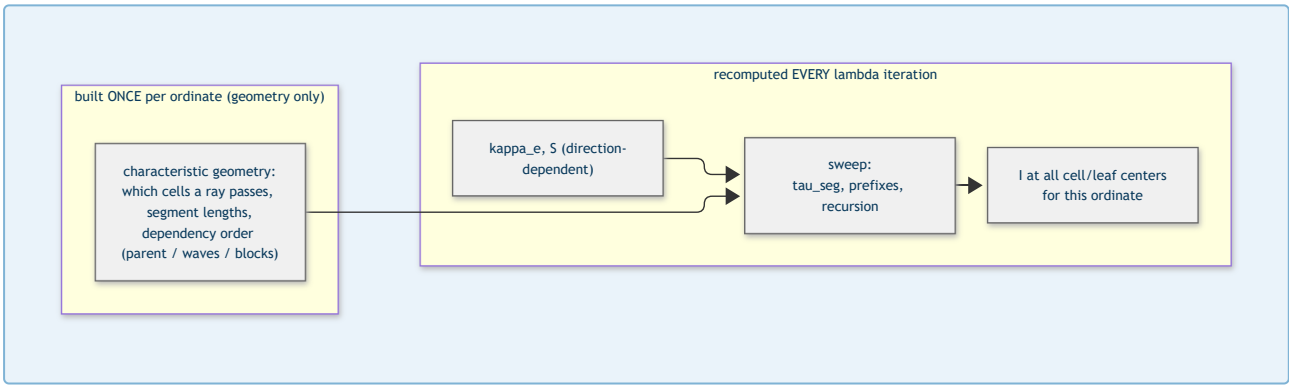
Two conventions used consistently in the code:

- $1 - e^{-\tau}$ is computed as `-np.expm1(-tau)` (accurate for optically thin segments);
- segment blocks are stored either **center → entry** (root chains, exact octree marches) or **parent → target** (interior chains). The attenuation factor of a segment is then `exp(-prefix_before)` in the first ordering and `exp(-(tau_tot - prefix_through))` in the second — see §4.3 and the figure in §4.4.

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2. Shared architecture of both grids

Both grids expose the same interface to the transport — cell/leaf centers, domain box, O(1) point location — and both sweeps follow the same two-phase pattern:



Because the characteristic geometry depends only on *grid + direction*, it is built once per ordinate and reused across all iterations (`chains` / `marches` arguments of `sweep_all*`, and `solver.lambda_iteration`). Only κ_e and S change between iterations.

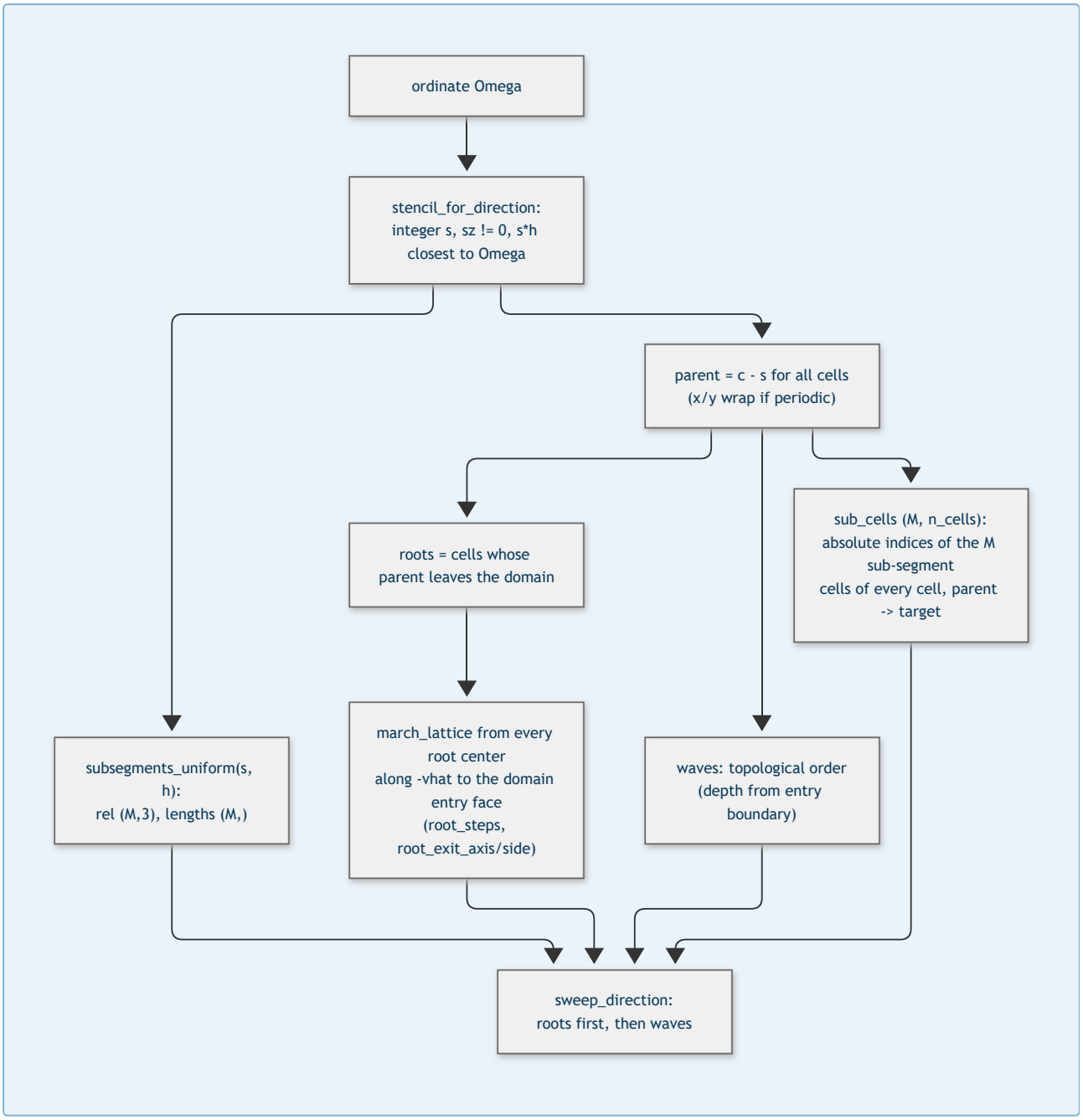
The dependency structure is a **forest**: every characteristic ends at a domain entry face (the *root* chains) and every other cell's intensity is computed from its upwind predecessor. The reason this never cycles is that **every ordinate has** $\Omega_z \neq 0$ (guaranteed by the direction-grid rotation, plan §4) and z is the only non-periodic dimension — along any chain, z moves monotonically toward an entry face.

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3. Unigrid: lattice stencil chains

Files: `characteristics.build_chain` + `transport.sweep_direction`.

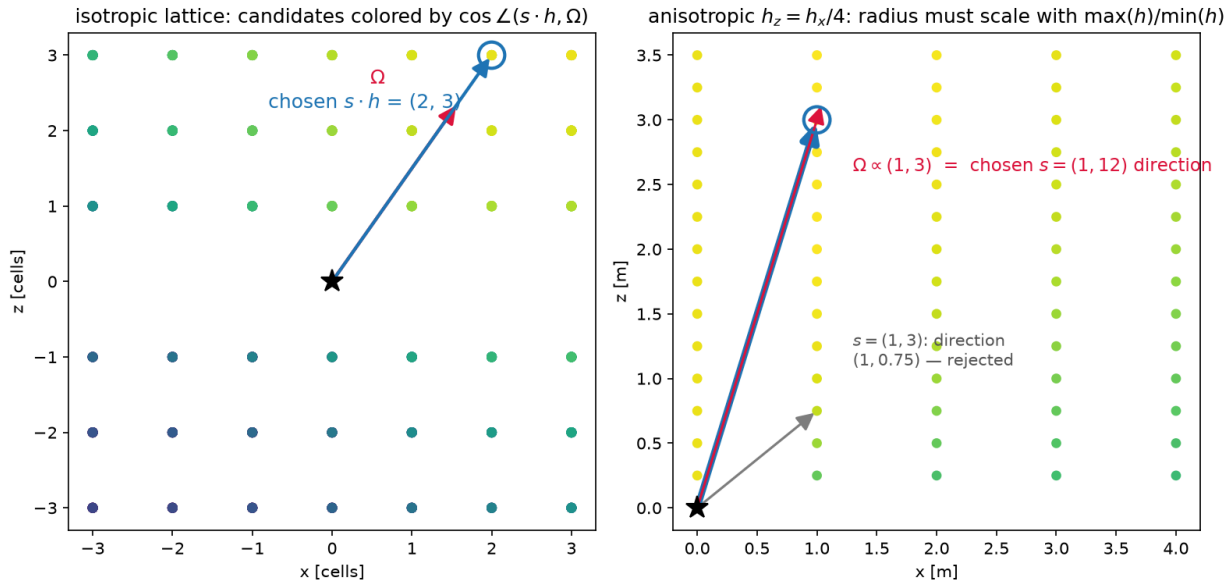
The key idea: on a uniform Cartesian lattice, *one integer stencil* $s = (s_x, s_y, s_z)$ per ordinate describes the upwind connection of **every** cell ($u = c - s$), and the sub-segment decomposition of the straight path $u_{\text{center}} \to c_{\text{center}}$ is the *same relative offsets and lengths for every cell*. The whole sweep becomes a handful of vectorized gathers per topological wave.



3.1 Stencil selection (`stencil_for_direction`)

The upwind cell of c is $c - s$ where s is the lattice offset whose physical direction $s \cdot h$ is closest to $\boldsymbol{\Omega}$ (bipolar / Rybicki–Hummer connection, specialized to a lattice):

- constraints: $s \neq 0$, $s_z \neq 0$ (chains must terminate in z);
- objective: maximize $\cos \angle(s \cdot h, \Omega)$;
- tie-break: prefer the **shorter** stencil (better memory locality, smaller waves);
- search radius: automatic, $\text{radius} = \min\big(24,\ \max(3, \lceil 3\ \max(h)/\min(h) \rceil)\big)$. A direction with slope $dz/dx \approx 3$ on a lattice with $h_z = h_x/4$ needs $s_z \approx 12$ — a fixed small radius leaves large, refinement-independent direction errors.

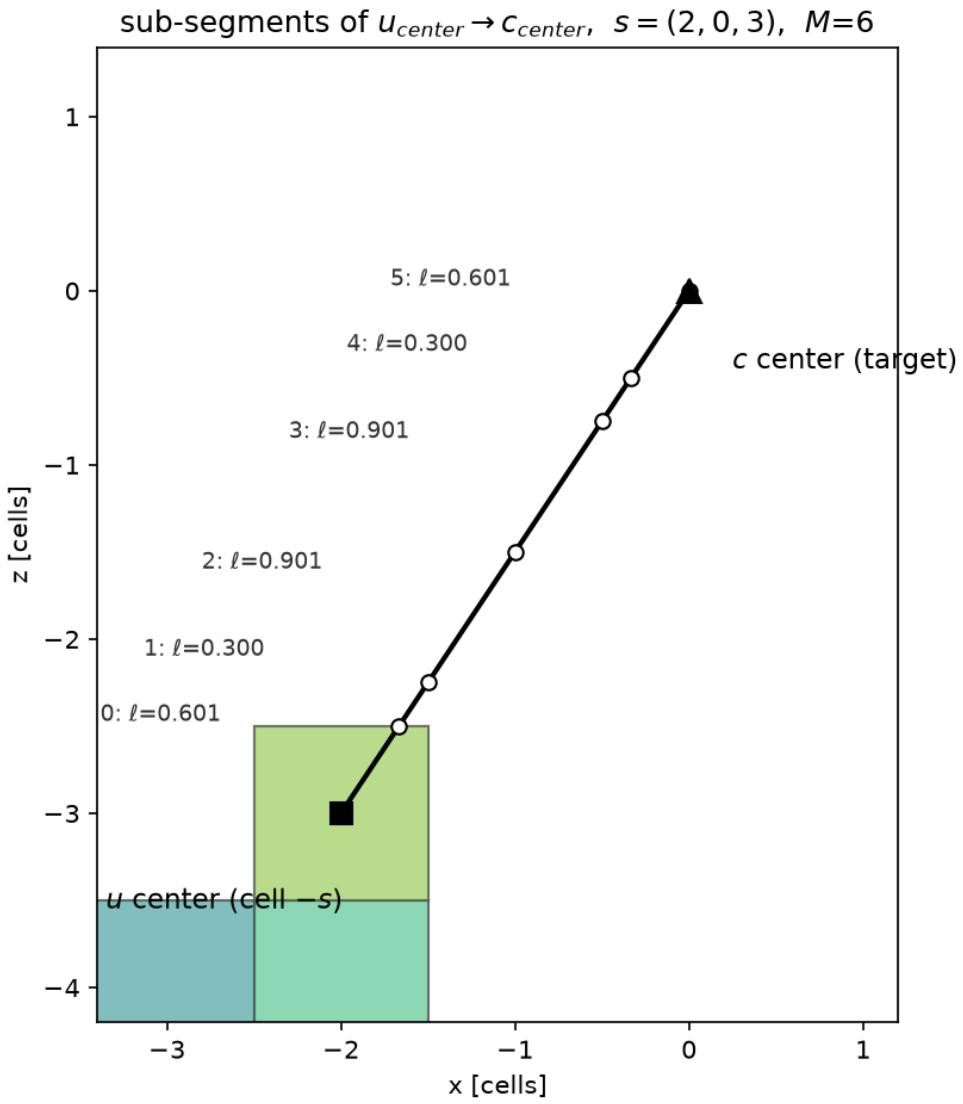


Left: candidate offsets on an isotropic lattice, colored by alignment; the chosen $s \cdot h$ (blue) approximates Ω (red). Right: on an anisotropic lattice the naive short stencil $(1, 3)$ points along $(1, 0.75)$ — far off $\Omega \propto (1, 3)$ — while the radius-scaled search finds the exact $(1, 12)$.

The actual characteristic direction is $\hat{v} = s \cdot h/|s \cdot h|$; the deviation $\angle(\hat{v}, \Omega)$ is the intrinsic **path error** of short characteristics on a lattice and converges with grid refinement.

3.2 Sub-segment splitting (`subsegments_uniform`)

The straight path from u_{center} to c_{center} crosses M cells; each crossing point is a sub-segment boundary. The split is computed in **lattice-normalized coordinates** $q = p/h$, where the path is $-s \to 0$ along $s/|s|$ and cell faces sit at half-integers; physical lengths are recovered by the scale $|s \cdot h|/|s|$.



Sub-segments of $u_{\text{center}} \to c_{\text{center}}$ for $s = (2, 0, 3)$, $h = (1, 1, 1)$: $M = 6$ segments with lengths 0.601, 0.300, 0.901, 0.901, 0.300, 0.601 — summing to $|s \cdot h| = \sqrt{13}$.

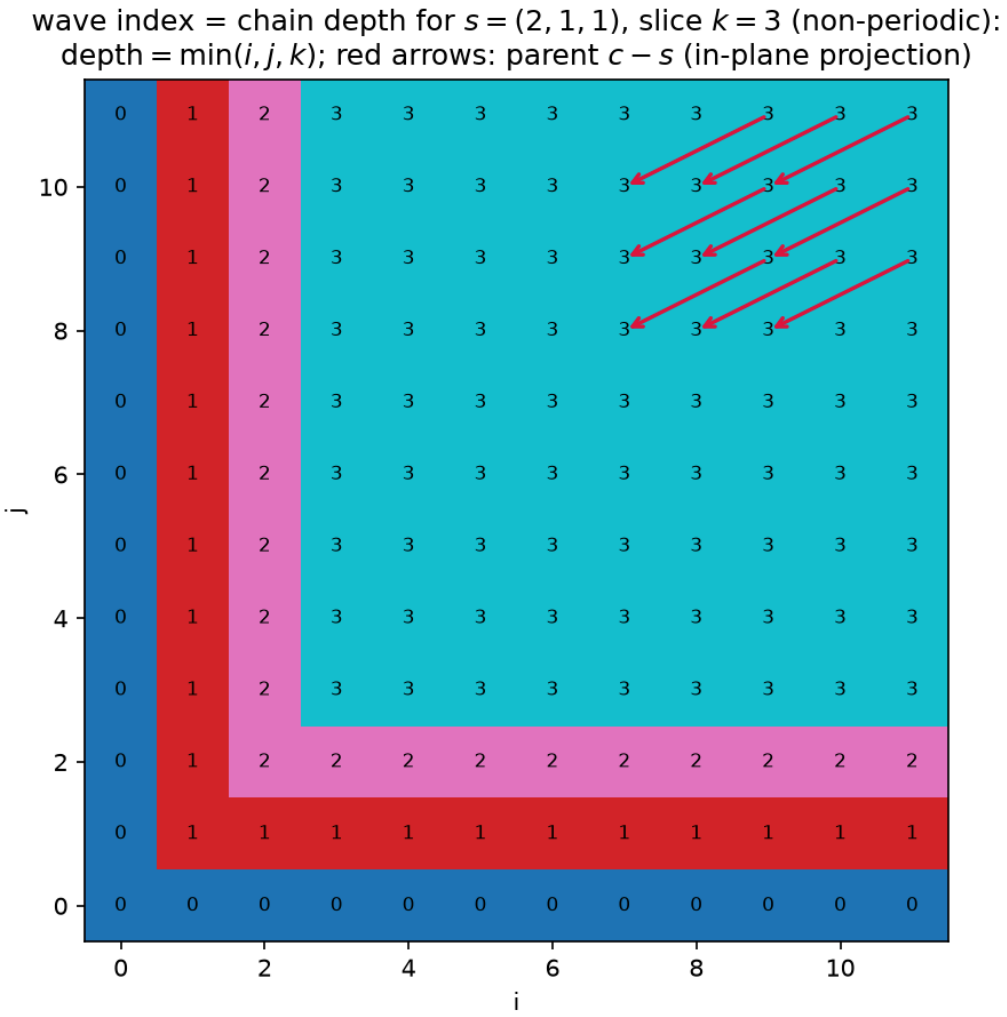
Because the relative offsets `rel (M,3)` and `lengths (M,)` are identical for every target cell, `build_chain` materializes them once as absolute indices `sub_cells (M, n_cells)` — the sweep then just gathers `sub_cells[m][wave]`.

3.3 Parent array, roots, topological waves

`parent[c] = c − s` (flat index), with x/y wrapping when the sides are periodic; cells whose parent leaves the domain are **roots**.

Waves are ordered by chain depth — the number of stencil hops from the entry boundary — so that every cell appears strictly after its parent:

- **periodic x/y**: only z decreases monotonically along a chain, so $\mathrm{depth} = k$ if $s_z > 0$, else $n_z - 1 - k$;
- **non-periodic**: $\mathrm{depth} = \min$ over the non-zero stencil axes of the distance to the upwind boundary along that axis.



Wave index (= chain depth) for $s = (2, 1, 1)$ on a $k = 3$ slice; a cell in wave d reads its parent from wave $< d$, so each wave is one batch of gathers.

3.4 Root chains: exact backward march to the entry face

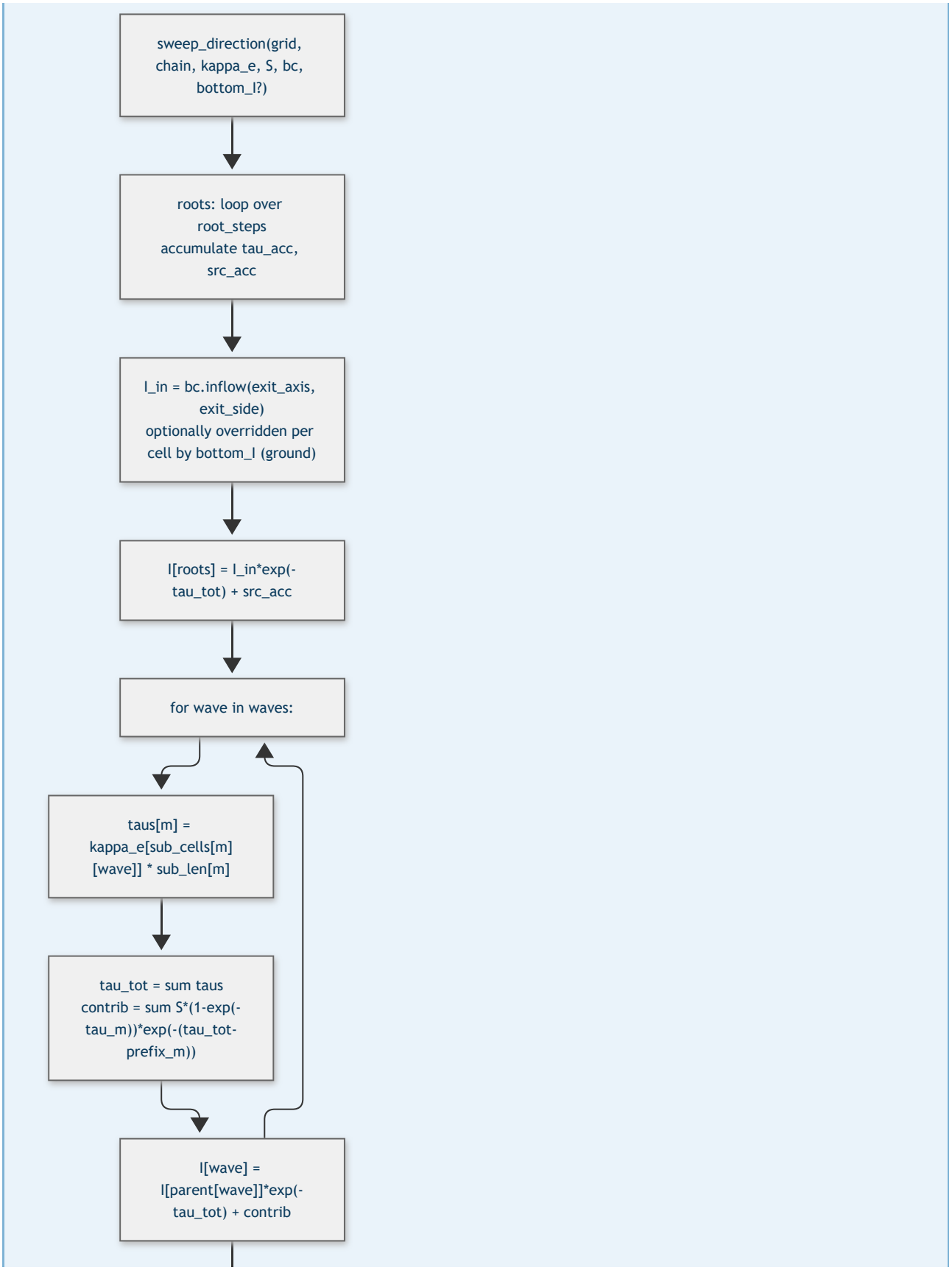
A root's characteristic does not start at another cell — it starts at the domain entry face. `march_lattice` (Amanatides-Woo DDA, vectorized over all roots simultaneously, with periodic wrap bookkeeping) marches each root center along $-\hat{v}$ and records the traversed cells and lengths (`root_steps`, step-major, ordered **center** → **entry**), plus the exit face (`root_exit_axis`, `root_exit_side`) that selects the inflow (§7).

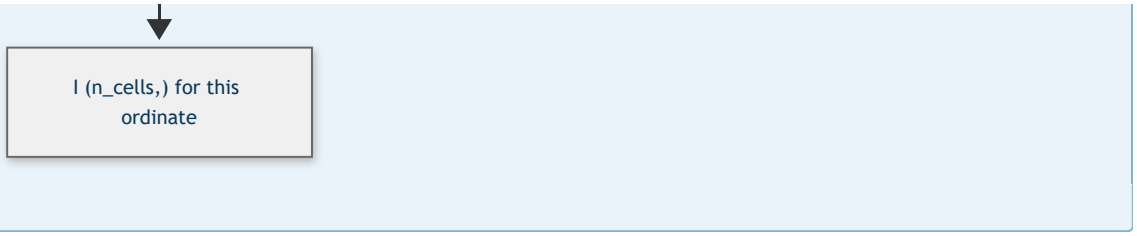
3.5 The sweep (`sweep_direction`)

```
# --- roots: segments ordered center → entry.
# The attenuation of a segment to the root center is exp(-tau_acc),
# where tau_acc sums the segments already visited (they lie between
# this segment and the center).
tau_acc = 0; src_acc = 0
for (ridx, cell, ln) in root_steps:            # step-major over all roots
    tau = kappa_e[cell] * ln
    src_acc[ridx] += S[cell] * (-expm1(-tau)) * exp(-tau_acc[ridx])
    tau_acc[ridx] += tau
I[roots] = I_in * exp(-tau_acc) + src_acc      # I_in from bc / ground

# --- interior cells, one gather batch per wave
for wave in waves:
    tau_tot = sum_m kappa_e[sub_cells[m][wave]] * sub_len[m]
    contrib = sum_m S[sub_cells[m][wave]] * (-expm1(-tau_m))
                     * exp(-(tau_tot - prefix_through_m))
    I[wave] = I[parent[wave]] * exp(-tau_tot) + contrib
```

Note the two orderings: root segments run **center → entry** (attenuation factor `exp(-prefix_before)`), interior sub-segments run **parent → target** (attenuation factor `exp(-(tau_tot - prefix_through))`). Both evaluate the same exact formal solution.


sweep_direction(grid, chain, kappa_e, S, bc, bottom_I?)
roots: loop over root_steps accumulate tau_acc, src_acc
I_in = bc.inflow(exit_axis, exit_side) optionally overridden per cell by bottom_I (ground)
I[roots] = I_in*exp(-tau_tot) + src_acc
for wave in waves:
taus[m] = kappa_e[sub_cells[m][wave]] * sub_len[m]
tau_tot = sum taus contrib = sum S*(1-exp(-tau_m))*exp(-(tau_tot-prefix_m))
I[wave] = I[parent[wave]]*exp(-tau_tot) + contrib



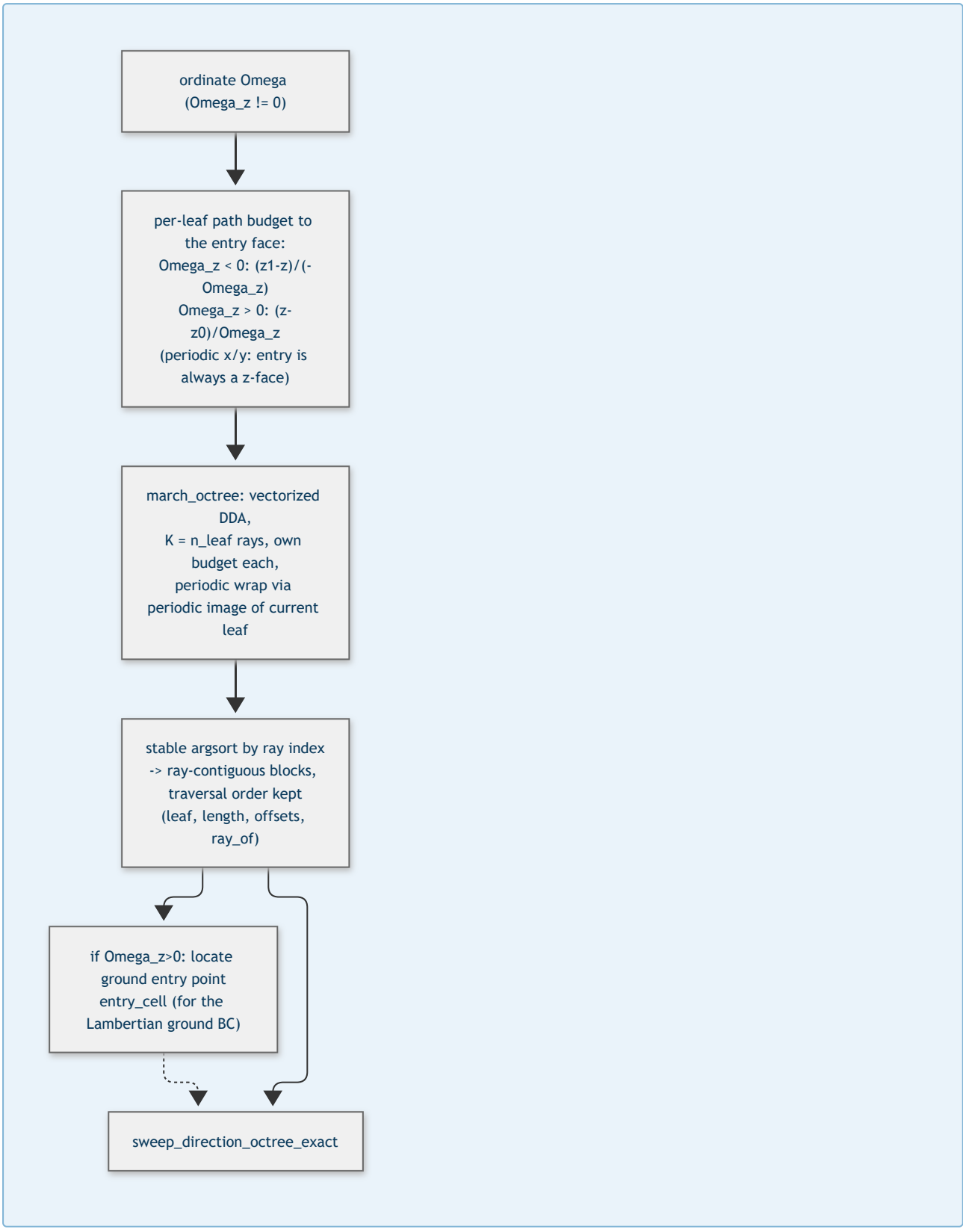
`sweep_all` loops over ordinates; S may be `(n_cells,)` or `(n_cells, N_dir)` — the latter is what anisotropic (HG) scattering requires.

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4. Octree: exact characteristic marches

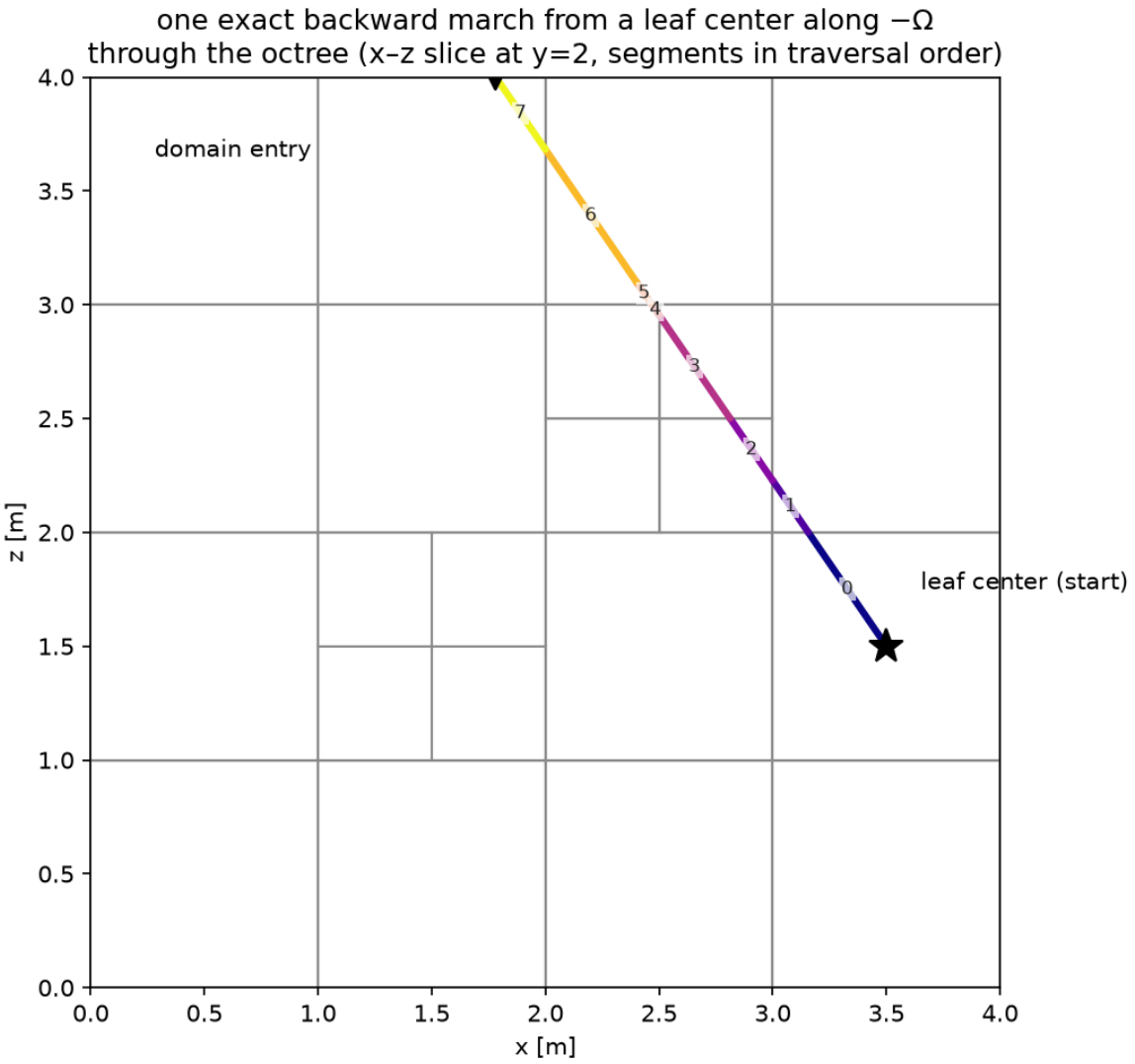
Files: `transport.precompute_octree_march` + `transport.sweep_direction_octree_exact` (used by the solver), with `octree.march_octree` as the DDA engine.

On the graded octree there is no single lattice stencil. The solver therefore abandons the center-to-center chain here and marches the **true ray** through the tree: one backward ray from every leaf center to the domain entry point. The only remaining path error is then the octree's own field resolution — there is no stencil direction error at all.


ordinate Omega
(Omega_z != 0)
per-leaf path budget to the entry face:
Omega_z < 0: (z1-z)/(-Omega_z)
Omega_z > 0: (z-z0)/Omega_z
(periodic x/y: entry is always a z-face)
march_octree: vectorized DDA,
K = n_leaf rays, own budget each,
periodic wrap via periodic image of current leaf
stable argsort by ray index -> ray-contiguous blocks, traversal order kept
(leaf, length, offsets, ray_of)
if Omega_z>0: locate ground entry point entry_cell (for the Lambertian ground BC)
sweep_direction_octree_exact

4.1 The DDA march (`march_octree`)

All n_{leaf} rays advance in lockstep per traversal step (step-major, like `march_lattice`): for each still-active ray, the distance to the next face of its **current leaf** is $(c_{\text{leaf}} \pm h_{\text{leaf}} - p)/d$ per axis, the minimum wins, the segment `(ray, leaf, length)` is recorded, and the ray is re-`locate`d (vectorized tree descent) after crossing. With periodic x/y the face distances use the periodic image of the current leaf closest to the ray position. Each ray carries its own path-length **budget**, so a ray simply stops at the domain entry point.



One backward march from a leaf center along $-\Omega$ through a balanced octree (x-z slice); segments are numbered in traversal order (center → entry).

4.2 Ray-contiguous block layout

`march_octree` returns step-major segments (`seg_ray` nondecreasing per step). `precompute_octree_march` regroups them with a **stable** argsort by ray index, which keeps the traversal order *within* each ray:

```
leaf    = [L01 L02 L03 L04 | L11 L12 | L21 L22 L23]   (segment's leaf)
length  = [ 0.7  1.3  0.4  0.9 | 1.1  0.6 | 0.5  1.4  0.8 ]
offsets = [0     4            6          9]            (block boundaries)
ray_of  = [ 0    0    0    0  | 1    1   | 2    2    2 ]
```

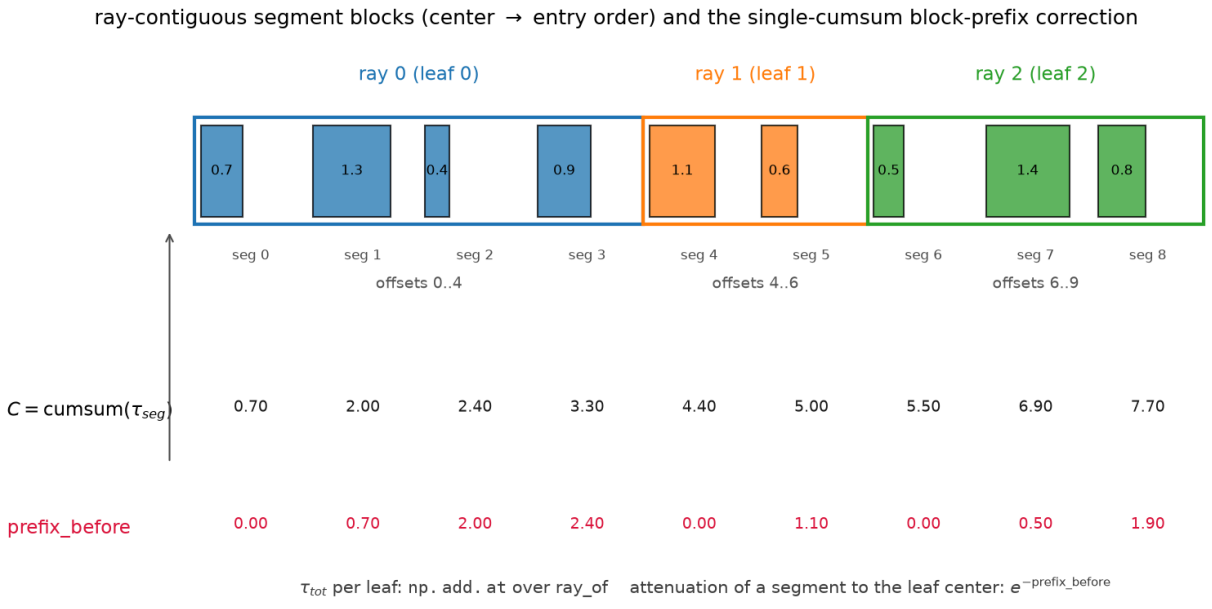
Segments of ray r (whose target is leaf r) occupy `[offsets[r], offsets[r+1])`, ordered **center → entry**.

4.3 Block prefixes with a single cumsum (`_block_prefixes`)

Per-segment optical depths $\tau_{\text{seg}} = \kappa_e[\text{leaf}] \cdot \ell$ are needed with *within-block* running sums. One global `np.cumsum` plus a per-block offset correction gives both prefixes:

$$C_m = \sum_{m' \le m} \tau_{\text{seg},m'}, \qquad \text{prev}_r = C_{\text{offsets}[r]-1}, \qquad \text{prefix}^{\text{before}}_m = C_m - \tau_{\text{seg},m} - \text{prev}_{r(m)}$$

(`prefix_through` is $C_m - \text{prev}_{r(m)}$). The per-ray totals τ_{tot} come from `np.add.at(tau_tot, ray_of, tau_seg)`.



Three rays, four/two/three segments each. The single cumsum row C is corrected by the value at the previous block end to give each segment's optical depth to its own leaf center.

4.4 The sweep (`sweep_direction_octree_exact`)

With segments ordered center → entry, the attenuation of a segment contribution to the leaf center is `exp(-prefix_before)`, and **no topological waves are needed at all** — each leaf's whole characteristic (entry → center)

is integrated in one shot, so the entire ordinate is one fully vectorized expression:

```
tau_seg    = kappa_e[leaf] * length
pre_before, _ = _block_prefixes(tau_seg, offsets)
tau_tot    = np.add.at over ray_of of tau_seg          # (n_leaf,)

I = np.add.at(S[leaf] * (-expm1(-tau_seg)) * exp(-pre_before))   # onto ray_of
I += I_in * exp(-tau_tot)          # or bottom_I[entry_cell] for upward rays
```

I_{in} is `bc.top_I` for downward ordinates ($\Omega_z < 0$, ray enters through the top) and `bc.bottom_I` / ground radiance for upward ones.

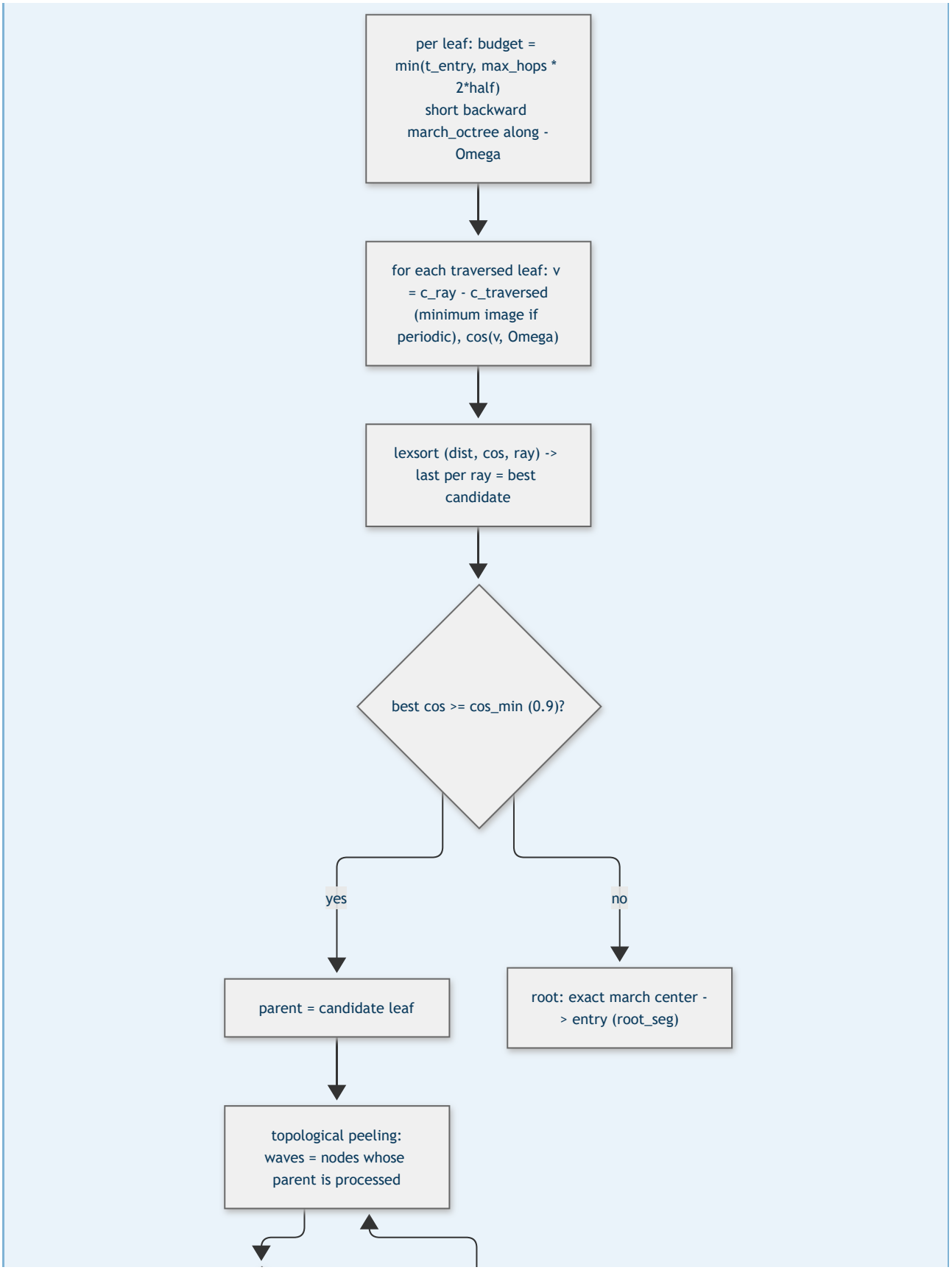
4.5 Ground entry cells

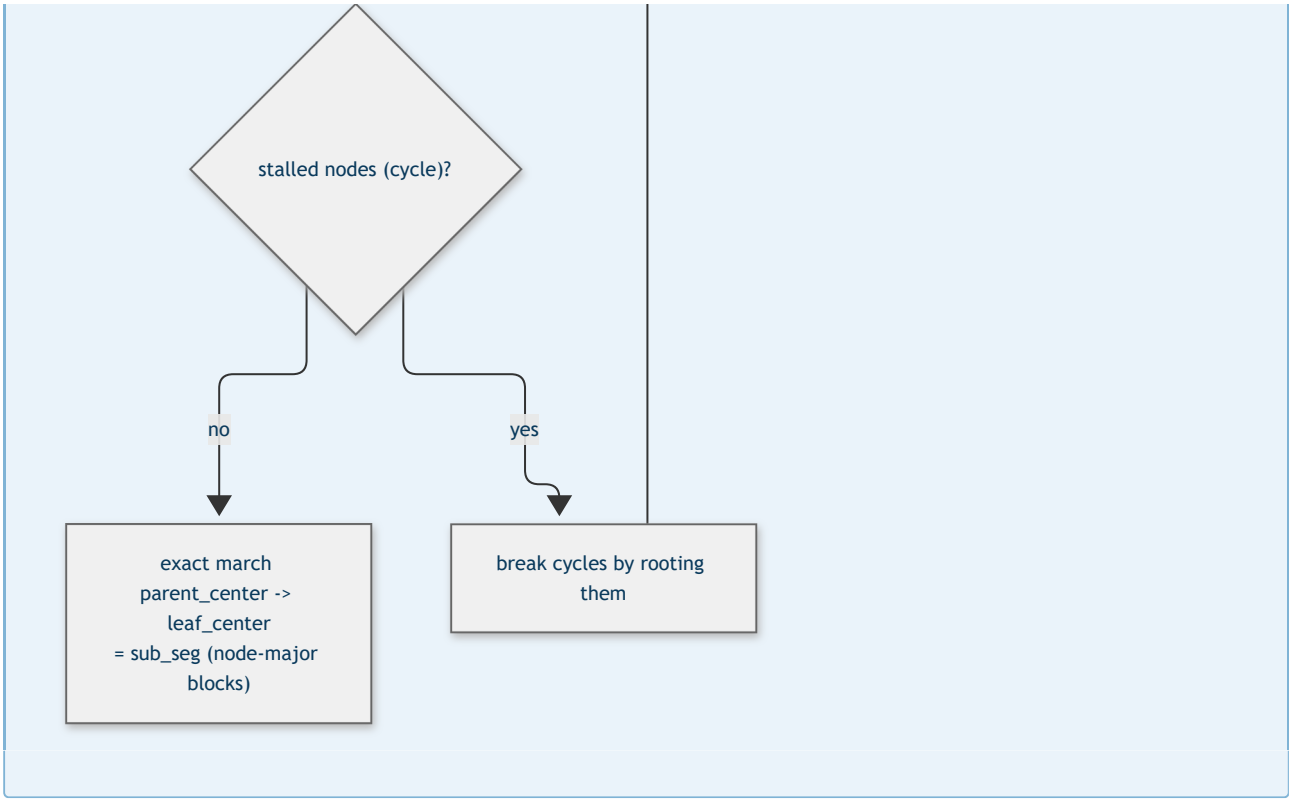
For upward ordinates the backward ray ends at the **ground plane**, not at a cell. `precompute_octree_march` additionally computes, per ray, the ground entry point $p = c_{\text{leaf}} - \text{budget} \cdot \Omega$ (wrapped into the periodic box, z clamped to z_0) and its leaf via `oct.locate` – `march["entry_cell"]`. The solver passes the Lambertian ground radiance evaluated per column as `bottom_I=I_g[chain["entry_cell"]]` (§7.2).

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5. The approximate octree chain (`build_chain_octree`) — reference

`characteristics.build_chain_octree` + `transport.sweep_direction_octree` implement the *same* center-to-center (bipolar) connection as the unigrid, generalized to the graded grid. It is kept as a reference implementation but **the solver does not use it**: the center-to-center connection showed non-converging path errors in heterogeneous 3D fields (the chosen predecessor center-to-center line can deviate from Ω by an amount that does not shrink with refinement on a graded grid). It is documented here because it is exercised by `scripts/phase3_octree.py` and its machinery (peeling, node-major segments) is instructive.


per leaf: budget = min(t_entry, max_hops * 2*half) short backward march_octree along -Omega
for each traversed leaf: v = c_ray - c_traversed (minimum image if periodic), cos(v, Omega)
lexsort (dist, cos, ray) -> last per ray = best candidate
best cos >= cos_min (0.9)?
yes
no
parent = candidate leaf
root: exact march center -> entry (root_seg)
topological peeling: waves = nodes whose parent is processed



- `cos_min` / `max_hops` bound both the direction error and the search cost.
- **Cycles**: unlike the lattice case, center-to-center connections on a graded grid can form dependency cycles. They are detected by *topological peeling* — when no remaining node has a processed parent, the remaining set is a union of cycles and is rooted (each such leaf then carries an exact march to the boundary, which is always valid).
- The sweep is the octree analogue of §3.5: root blocks (center → entry) first, then BFS waves over `sub_seg` blocks (parent → target); `tau_tot` / `contrib` are computed once per sweep because they depend only on κ_e and S, not on I.

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6. Beam optical depth sweeps

The direct solar beam is not on the quadrature; its attenuation τ_b at every cell/leaf center is computed with the *same* march machinery, with the source term dropped (pure absorption along the backward beam ray, physical κ_e even under delta-M):

grid	function	march	budget
unigrid	`transport.beam_optical_depth`	`march_lattice(centers, -omega_sun)`	to box exit
octree	`transport.beam_optical_depth_octree`	`march_octree(centers, -omega_sun)`	periodic: $(z_1-z)/

`beam_irradiance_ground` extends τ_b from the bottom-cell centers to the ground plane through the bottom cell itself: $\tau_g = \tau_b + \kappa_e(z - z_0)/|\mu_\odot|$, giving $F_0|\mu_\odot|e^{-\tau_g}$ at the ground.

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7. Boundary conditions inside the sweep

7.1 Face selection (`boundary_conditions.inflow`)

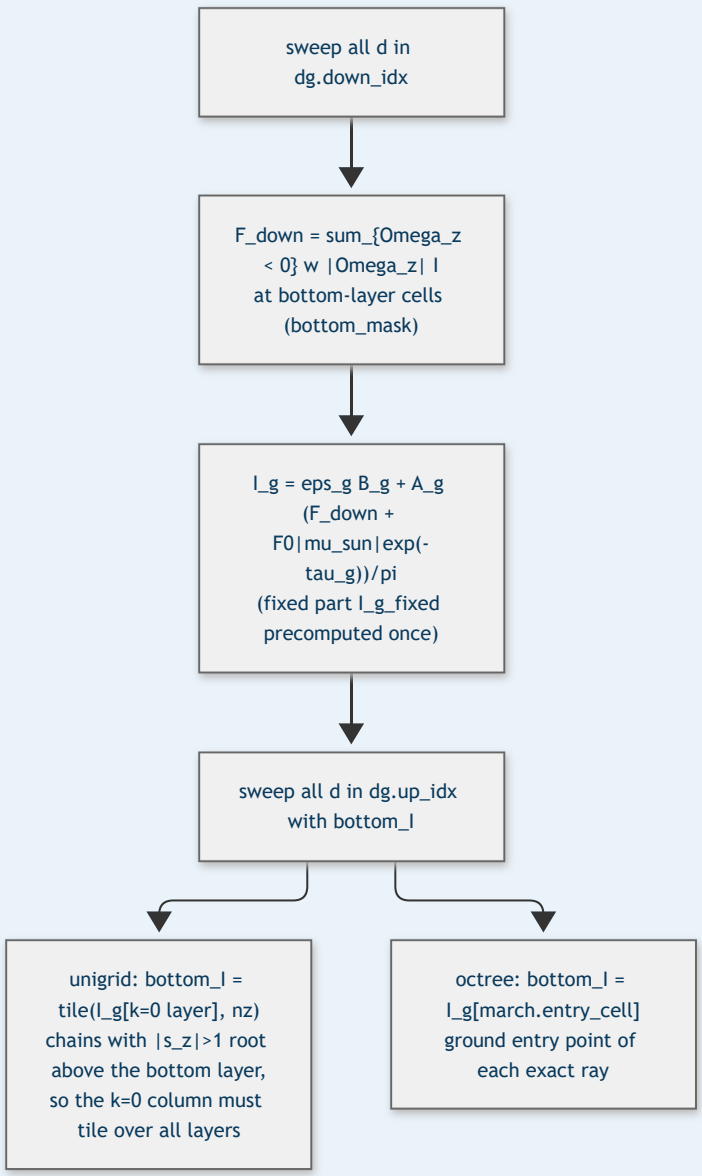
Each root chain knows the face its backward march exited through (`root_exit_axis`, `root_exit_side`):

```
exit_axis == 2, side > 0  →  top_I      (space)
exit_axis == 2, side < 0  →  bottom_I   (or ground radiance, §7.2)
exit_axis in {0, 1}       →  side_I     (ignored when x/y are periodic)
```

With periodic x/y the exit is always a z-face, so the side faces never appear.

7.2 Lambertian ground (phase 5)

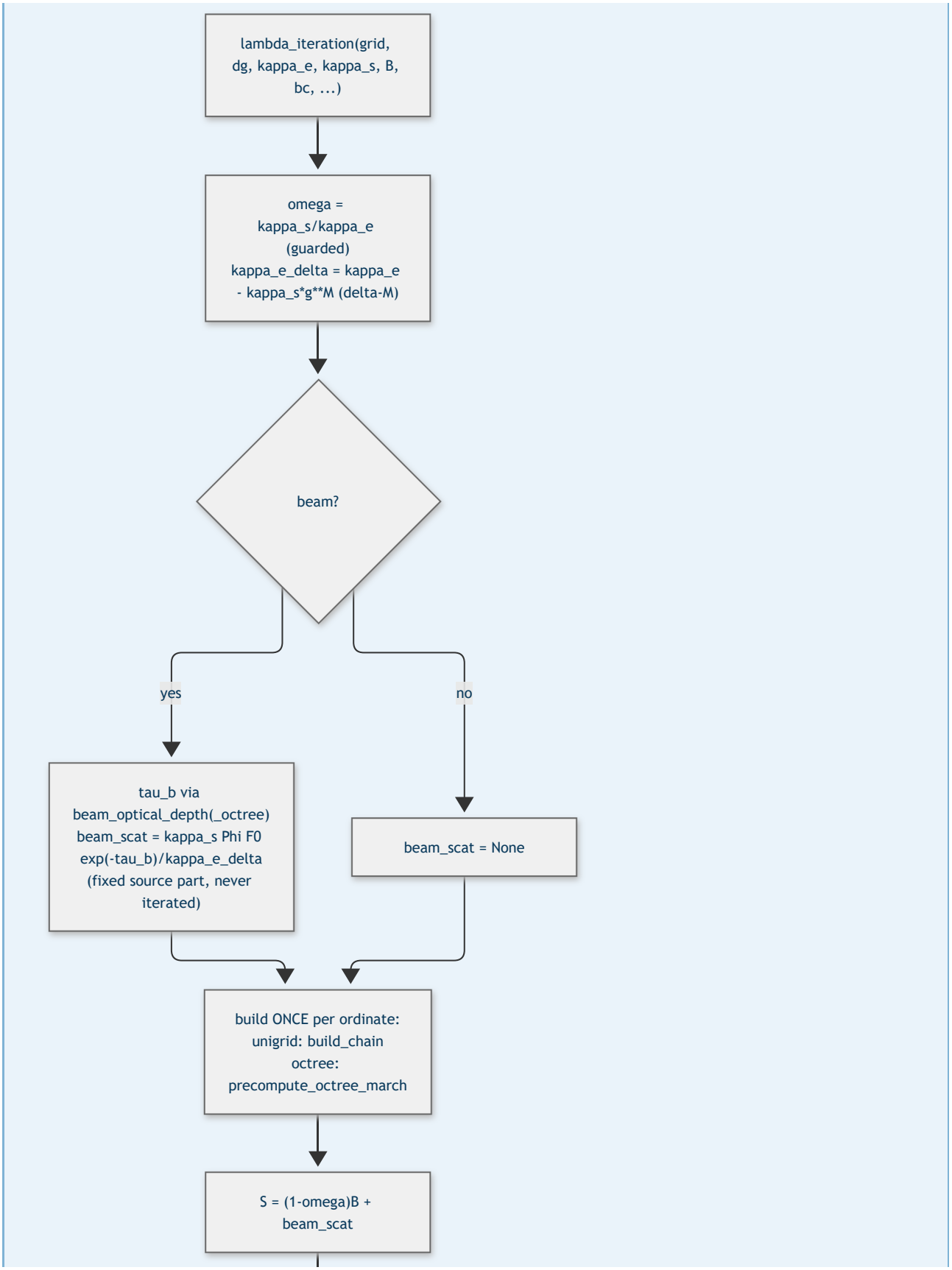
The ground radiance couples downward and upward ordinates; the solver therefore sweeps **downward ordinates first**, builds the ground radiance, then sweeps upward ones:

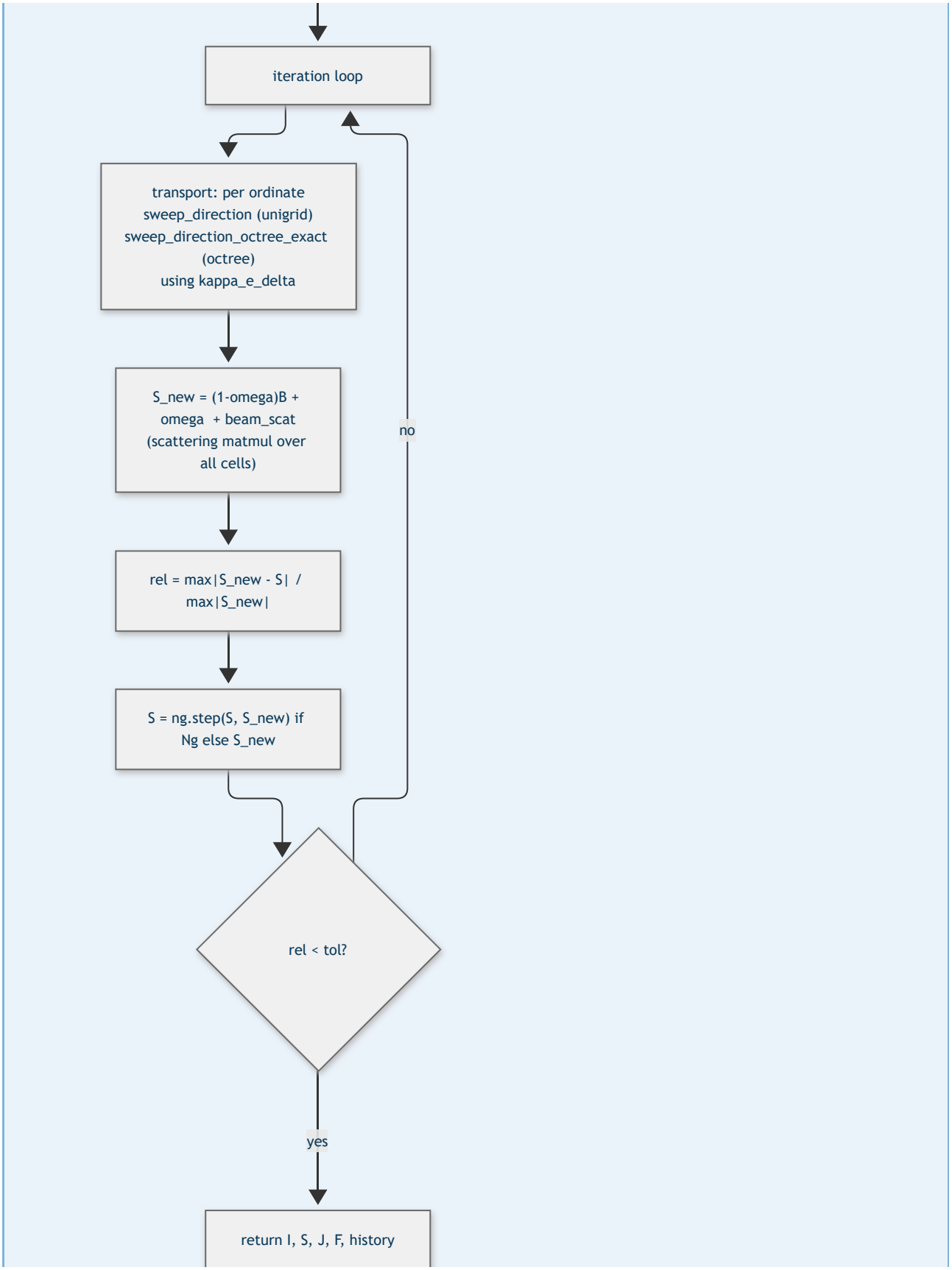


Tiling note (unigrid): a chain with $|s_z| > 1$ roots at layer $|s_z| - 1$, not at $k = 0$; the ground radiance is a column field, so the $k = 0$ values are tiled over all layers and only bottom-entry roots read them. *Octree:* no tiling needed — each ray knows its own ground entry leaf via `entry_cell`.

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8. Solver-level flowchart


lambda_iteration(grid, dg, kappa_e, kappa_s, B, bc, ...)
omega = kappa_s/kappa_e (guarded) kappa_e_delta = kappa_e - kappa_s*g**M (delta-M)
beam?
yes
no
tau_b via beam_optical_depth(_octree) beam_scat = kappa_s Phi F0 exp(-tau_b)/kappa_e_delta (fixed source part, never iterated)
beam_scat = None
build ONCE per ordinate: unigrid: build_chain octree: precompute_octree_march
S = (1-omega)B + beam_scat


iteration loop
transport: per ordinate
sweep_direction (unigrid)
sweep_direction_octree_exact
(octree)
using kappa_e_delta
S_new = (1-omega)B +
omega + beam_scat
(scattering matmul over
all cells)
rel = max|S_new - S| /
max|S_new|
S = ng.step(S, S_new) if
Ng else S_new
rel < tol?
no
yes
return I, S, J, F, history

The ground branch of the loop (§7.2) replaces the single transport block with the down-then-up ordering. Delta-M scales only the **diffuse** transport ($\kappa_e^{(\delta)}$ in the sweeps); the beam and the ground beam term keep the physical κ_e.

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9. Data-structure reference

`characteristics.build_chain` (unigrid) — one dict per ordinate

key	shape / type	meaning
`s`	(3,) int	lattice stencil, $s_z \neq 0$
`vhat`	(3,) float	characteristic unit direction $s\cdot h/
`parent`	(n_cells,) int	upwind cell $c - s$, `-1` for roots
`roots`	(R,) int	boundary-entry cells
`waves`	list of (n_w,) int	topological order; parent strictly earlier
`sub_cells`	(M, n_cells) int	sub-segment cells of every cell, parent → target
`sub_len`	(M,) float	sub-segment lengths (same for every cell)
`root_steps`	list of (ray, cell, len)	step-major DDA segments, root center → entry
`root_exit_axis/side`	(R,) int	entry face of each root chain

`transport.precompute_octree_march` — one dict per ordinate

key	shape / type	meaning
`leaf`	(M,) int	leaf of each segment, ray-contiguous blocks
`length`	(M,) float	segment lengths
`offsets`	(n_leaf+1,) int	block boundaries; ray r = `[offsets[r], offsets[r+1])`
`ray_of`	(M,) int	ray (= target leaf) index per segment
`omega`	(3,) float	ordinate direction
`entry_cell`	(n_leaf,) int or None	for $\Omega_z > 0$: bottom-face leaf at the ray's ground entry

`characteristics.build_chain_octree` (reference) — one dict per ordinate

key	shape / type	meaning
`parent`	(n_leaf,) int	best-aligned traversed leaf, `-1` for roots
`roots`	(R,) int	rooted leaves (no candidate / cycle-broken)
`waves`	list of arrays	peeling order (parent before child)
`root_seg`	(ray, leaf, len, offsets)	node-major blocks, root center → entry
`root_exit_axis/side`	(R,) int	entry face of each root
`sub_seg`	(ray, leaf, len, offsets)	node-major blocks, parent center → leaf center

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10. Performance and memory notes

- **Geometry reuse dominates.** Chain/march construction is $O(N_{\text{dir}} \times \text{march})$ once; every iteration is pure gather/accumulate.
- **Unigrid memory:** `sub_cells` is (M, n_{cells}) int — with anisotropic grids M grows with the stencil radius cap (up to 24/axis), so this array dominates memory on large lattices.
- **Octree march size:** the segment count M is bounded by $\sum_r \text{budget}_r \cdot \sum_i |d_i|/h_{\min}$; deep refinement near a cloud multiplies the segments of rays crossing it.
- `np.add.at` (octree accumulation) is the slower scatter primitive; it is unavoidable for node-major accumulation but runs once per sweep, not per segment loop.
- Wave count on the unigrid is the max chain depth (n_z for periodic x/y); each wave is a few vectorized gathers, so sweep cost $\approx N_{\text{dir}} \times M \times n_{\text{cells}}$ elementwise operations.

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11. Validation anchors touching transport

From `AGENTS.md` / MANUAL §14 — which sweep property each anchors:

anchor	what it checks in the transport	runner
3	$\kappa_s = 0$, $B = 0 \Rightarrow I = I_{\text{in}} e^{-\tau}$ along **every** characteristic — pure recursion + march correctness	`scripts/phase1_beer.py`
4	$\nabla \cdot F$ = heating rate from I — quadrature + sweep energy consistency	MANUAL §11 worked example
5	octree result converges to the unigrid result on the Gaussian cloud — both transport paths agree in the refinement limit	`scripts/phase3_octree.py`

Figure regeneration: `scripts/sc_transport_figures.py` → `plot/sc_stencil_lattice.png`, `sc_subsegments.png`, `sc_bfs_waves.png`, `sc_octree_march.png`, `sc_block_prefixes.png`.